

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in an Australian newspaper:

Urban beekeeping: A good idea?

Thousands have taken up urban beekeeping in Sydney. The reaction from neighbours is not always positive. Rob Simms has three beehives in his garden, and gives away jars of honey to keep his neighbours sweet. "I delayed doing anything for six months because I thought I wouldn't get neighbour approval," Simms said. "Now I give people jars of honey and everyone's happy."



But the beekeeping boom has created problems for urban living. Catherine Heath, a resident, considers herself pro-bee. However, this spring her garden has become a no-go zone because of aggressive bees, and she noticed an adjoining house had a sign on the front fence advertising homegrown honey. "It's to the point that in good weather, we can't use the backyard most of the time," Heath says. "There are a lot of bees and they behave in a strange way. They attack both dogs and humans unprovoked."

Douglas Purdie, president of Sydney Bee Club, said this was not unheard of. "Bees, like all wild things, go through cycles and temperament, just like you can have a dog that's very nice today and tomorrow bites you," he said.

The Department of Primary Industries says Sydney has over 15,000 registered beekeepers and around 400,000 hives. Dr Tobias Smith, a researcher at the University of Queensland, comments that native Australian bees are stingless. "If you have flowers around, they will just do their own thing, and you sit back and enjoy watching them," Smith said. "They're a really easy pet."

You are members of your student council. You are discussing if it is a good idea to put a beehive on the school campus as a biology project. You may want to talk about:

- benefits of beekeeping at school
- problems that beekeeping could cause at school
- other activities that could help students to learn about bees
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you like honey?
2. Are you scared of bees?
3. Would you like to have an insect as a pet?
4. Would you like to keep bees?
5. How can schools make beekeeping safe for students?
6. Would your neighbours be upset if you took up beekeeping?
7. Do you think Hong Kong is suitable for urban beekeeping?
8. How else can schools promote a connection with nature?